in separate individual pits, validated for now by a DNA identification number till identities are confirmed, enabling relatives to come forward later, say officials.

"We are passing through a catastrophic moment in Kerala's history. Two villages in Wayanad have turned into graveyards. Our first priority is completing search and rescue. At the same time, we are planning a massive rehabilitation project with the support of the people," state finance minister K.N. Balagopal told INDIA TODAY. Already, the chief minister's disaster relief fund (CMDRF) has received over Rs 500 crore as donations. A detailed scientific plan is being readied so that future tragedies can be avoided in ecologically sensitive but inhabited areas.

SEARCH AND RESCUE

- **140-odd people still missing, over 500 rescued. A 1,700-strong search and rescue team still combing the region**
- **State planning massive rehabilitation programme, scientific study to prevent such tragedies in the future**
- **The Centre's new draft notification on Ecologically Sensitive Areas includes 13 villages in Wayanad. Total: 9,983 sq. km in Kerala**

The base camp for the search operations is Chooralmala. The region has been divided into seven zones, assigned to a 1,700-strong posse drawn from the National Disaster Response Force, Indian Army, Kerala Police, fire and rescue department, dog squad, forest department and 900-odd volunteers. Search operations are also on along the banks of the Chaliyar river, 40 km from Chooralmala, where 76 bodies and 180 body parts were recovered. One big challenge in the rescue efforts was upstream: the lost link between Chooralmala and Mundakkai. The landslide had washed away the concrete bridge, but an army team led by Maj. Gen. V.T. Mathew put in place a 190-foot Bailey bridge in less than two days. Some 400 people used to live in the higher reaches of Mundakkai, less than 50 have survived. Over 500 people stranded in remote areas have been saved so far. Some 4,000 volunteers from across the state have joined relief ops. "Around 1,400 police personnel too have been working round-the-clock since July 29," says M.R. Ajithkumar, ADGP, law and order.

As with earlier calamities that have befallen the state, Kerala has shown great resilience in the face of the tragedy. Survivors in Chooralmala have opened their homes and kitchens for the rescue and relief operation teams. Several unknown villagers have also emerged as heroes, providing timely help. Shaija Baby, a housewife and part-time ASHA worker in Mundakkai, has become a sort of data bank in helping identify the deceased. "I do what I can. I knew almost everybody who lives in Mundakkai and Chooralmala since in the past I've been a Kudumbhashree and ward member, and also served a term as vice-president of the Meppadi panchayat," says Shaija, who is now stationed at the Meppadi Family Health Care Centre where the deceased are kept for identification.

A 45-year-old widow and mother of two, she is a Mundakkai native who shifted to Meppadi in 2020 after a landslide near her residence. She says it's the least she can do as the people of the locality had been a great support system after her husband passed away in the UAE a few years back. She has so far helped identify more than 100 bodies from Chooralmala and Mundakkai.

The survivors have encountered the worst. Kalathingal Noufal arrived from Oman to find that he had lost 11 members of his family, including his parents, wife Sajna and their three children. Only five of the bodies have been recovered so far, the other six are listed as missing. Of their house in Mundakkai, only the basement remains among the giant rocks that have rolled in from the hills.

"We are left with nothing. No houses, no land to cultivate and no cattle to tend. Overnight, our village has turned into barren land," says Meppadi panchayat president K. Babu. His family was one of the lucky ones; their home was one of the last in Mundakkai (on the way to Punchirimattom) and the landslides took a different course that night. This is another major challenge for the state, rehabilitating the survivors from that terrible night. Many of them are still in shock, with the orphaned children being the worst affected. The state government has deployed counsellors for now and set up a helpline, but a longer term plan will have to be put in place for them.

Kerala has been facing one disaster after another since 2017 when the Ockhi cyclone killed over 100 people. The megafloods in 2018 and 2019 were followed by the Nipah virus and Covid-19, all of which have taken a toll on the people and the state's economy. The latest has been the landslides, which have made life impossible in Wayanad.

More troubles are on the way. The Centre's new draft notification in the wake of the disaster designates 56,800 sq. km of the Western Ghats across six states—including 13 villages in Wayanad—as Ecologically Sensitive Areas (ESAs). Around 123 villages in the state, with close to a million residents, lie on slopes with a 35 to 60 degree gradient. In all, over 9,983 sq. km in the state—across 13 of the 14 districts—could be declared ESAs if the notification is cleared, affecting the lives of 30 per cent of the population. In Mundakkai, a broken billboard says, 'Look for something positive each day, even if some days you have to look a little harder'. No one knows who came up with the line, not even if he or she is alive, but it sounds prophetic now. Kerala will have to take a real hard look at itself in the coming days. There will be no easy answers. ■